

Roger Rabbit

Meeting David

Is he wearing dentures? Or are his teeth that clean? How old is this man? And why is he wearing the same pair of shoes I wore during my 5th grade basketball season? I had just missed my bus stop for my campsite that evening. I was dropped off a couple miles down the road with this man.

Jedediah Smith Redwoods State Park was situated 10 miles from the Pacific Ocean. Lush green moss dripped from the towering redwoods. I was recommended this site for two reasons. It was the film site of Endor, the home of the Ewok species, in Star Wars Episode VI: Return of the Jedi. But most importantly, it housed the Smith River—one of the clearest and cleanest rivers in the world. “Oh, the swimming holes are amazing, you have to check it out while you’re here.” Based on the word, I pictured a hot tub-sized indent in the forest, nothing to become too excited over, but I wanted to check it out nonetheless.

As we crossed the street, the man introduced himself as David. “Hey, I’m going to the campsite too, I’ll walk with you. But first I’m going to stop inside the store to grab a drink and a razor. Do you want one?”

“I don’t need a drink, but we can split a pack of razors.”

“Sounds good.”

I situated myself at a picnic table in front of the gas station and glanced over at his pack. His pack was larger than mine, and it didn’t even have a sleeping pad. Who was he and what was he doing?

David came out, placed the two-pack of pink BIC razors on the picnic table, and cracked open a tallboy Bud Light.

“Man, I haven’t been up here yet. I typically stay near Clam Beach, 75 miles south. It’s \$7 a night to stay at Clam Beach. Right on the coast, there’s a store nearby. Nice and easy. Where are you coming from?”

“I’ve been in the Mojave Desert the past month. But I’m coming from LA and making my way up to Seattle to see a buddy.”

“Man, isn’t that great! We’re on two sides of the spectrum of life, doing the same thing! I haven’t done this since I was 17. I grabbed a backpack, bought a bus ticket, and I was off!”

“That is so sweet. Where are you off to this time around?”

“Now I’m 68. I figure I have 13 years left. So I’m going around saying my goodbyes. I played baseball with a pair of brothers, the Hall brothers, and I heard they have a place up in Smith River. I figure I’ll go up there and start asking people, ‘Do you know Michael and Jerry Hall?’ Hahaha. Maybe they’ll even let me camp on their land! Say, I went up a few weeks ago and found a great spot across from the casino. It was right across from the casino down in a ditch that no one would ever come to find! But my phone was low on battery so I went into the casino to charge my phone with one of the slot machines. I felt bad not spending money there so I put \$5 in the slot machine. I won \$150! Would you look at that!”

I couldn’t stop laughing. “When’s the last time you saw the Hall brothers?”

“19... 19... that must’ve been... 1973. Senior year of high school.”

The sun had just over an hour of hang time remaining. I didn’t know who he was but I liked his vibe. I didn’t know if there were available spots at the campsite down the road. I had spent the past two nights stealth camping along the side of the road and off a hiking trail; I could and would do it again. There was so much peace in this unknown space. So much excitement nestled itself around the corner waiting to be discovered.

David casually sipped on his tallboy. “I’ll tell you what, don’t listen to anybody. Because what works for someone might not work for you. You’ve gotta go out and find out for yourself. I’ve been in aviation. My grandfather pioneered aerial firefighting. I’ve owned an electronics store. My family is involved in racing, look us up! Vennable Racing! But I raised a family and bought a house as a truck driver. I didn’t quite handle my money responsibly, but I can tell that you will. There’s something about you.”

David finished his beer, I put the razor in my toiletry kit, and we began the trek to the campsite.

“Who even knows if they have a spot for us? All I need is a space this big!” David fully extended his arms, first in a vertical then a horizontal fashion. “I just need space for my tent! Hopefully they have a patch of grass big enough for my tent!”

Walking alongside the road, a car whizzed by us. With each step and push off the ground, pebbles were sent in every direction. The air became more crisp as the sun tucked itself behind the forest wall.

“I would tell you my Sasquatch stories but I don’t want you to think I’m an absolute basket case!”

Finally we arrived. The wooden sign of Jedediah Smith Redwoods State Park read: CAMPSITE OCCUPIED. We hurried to the ranger booth to see what the deal was.

“We’re looking for a campsite tonight,” we told the attendant.

“Well, our electric hookup spots are all taken for the weekend. But we have some spots open in our hiker-biker camp. Will you be camping together?” the ranger asked.

I looked at David.

He said, “Hey, it’s your call.”

“Yeah, let’s do it.”

Book + Trekking

My search for a meaningful life really took off one fall morning my senior year. I skipped my business operations class feeling extremely giddy to caddy for the first time that afternoon. Ever since I read *Bud, Sweat, and Tees* by Alan Shipnuck a few years prior, I knew I wanted to be a professional caddy.

The story details an unlikely partnership of a golf pro and his caddy's rise to a PGA championship.

I found myself at a hipster cafe a few blocks north of my college house. Too excited to complete any homework yet not ready to leave, I stared at the bookshelf. Books had price tags like those of grocery items: \$6.00, \$11.00, \$9.00. The one that caught my eye was \$5.00. This would change the direction of my life.

Walden by Henry David Thoreau details the author's experience living off the grid for 2 years, 2 months, and 2 days. He was in search of the essential facts of life and wanted to connect with nature on a deeper level. I did not see a business future for myself and continually questioned the typical path of a young adult. This thought process created a desire for another route. Stepping off of the rational path, I found myself on one rooted in intuition. First skipping the business class to come across *Walden*. This opened up a hipster portal I wanted to delve deeper into. Prior to my last semester, I walked into a wood-fired pizza shop and asked, "Do you guys need any help?"

They brought me on. I cooked pizzas with fire. One team member introduced me to work exchanges, as they had lived in Hawaii and Oregon on work exchange.

Following graduation I found a work exchange in the Mojave Desert on a sustainable building project. While I was connected to the essence of nature and pondering life, I read *Into the Wild* by Jon Krakauer. It details the bold yet reckless life of the young Chris McCandless in his adventures across the country. These adventures led to his demise in the Alaskan bush, where he died of starvation in a bus. Yet in each prior adventure he connected deeper to the natural world and happened to build a meaningful relationship with a complete stranger. I have no intentions of sending it alone off the grid, but rather longed for happenstance interactions! The inspiration to vagabond like Chris McCandless meshed well with the desire to see friends in LA and Seattle. Rather than flying from one city to the other, I wanted to fully explore the West Coast and rough it.

I was grateful to be with David at that moment. The prior night was spent solo stealth camping. Stealth camping is camping somewhere in society as opposed to a designated site. Yet that was never the plan.

The first leg of this trek consisted of a 26-hour train/bus route. There were 4 stops. LA to Santa Barbara to Emeryville (Oakland) to Martinez (Oakland) to Eureka. I left LA at 6 pm to arrive in Santa Barbara just past sunset. We single-filed onto a packed bus with a 9-hour ride north. The bus arrived at the Emeryville train station well before sunrise. The garage doors were shut, no lights were on inside, yet people waited outside. There were no more than a dozen of them and something told me they had been there for a while. Their gaze was dense and the air was crisp so I found the nearest diner.

Oh, to wrap my fingers around a warm cup of joe! My pack sat next to me in the booth. It felt like my companion and I enjoyed its company. My pack was my home, closet, kitchen, and library. It carried my 1-person tent. My 30-degree sleeping bag. My ground tarp and sleeping pad. My two shirts, two pairs of pants, and a few pairs of socks and underwear. It carried my cook set and a couple days' worth of food. Most of all, it carried my books.

Reading wasn't always my forte. While it was a passion as a young child, it turned into a chore in grade school. I did not enjoy the books we read as a class and I dreaded going to the library. That changed in 5th grade with Mrs. Quell.

Mrs. Quell was the reading teacher. She was a mom herself and had boys older and younger than me. She played volleyball and was well connected in the community. Having her as a teacher was refreshing because I was accustomed to nuns or 65-year-olds. I told her about my reading qualms and she recommended a book: *Because of Mr. Terp*.

She didn't hand me a book or tell me where to acquire it; it was merely word of mouth. So I decided to buy it on my iPod touch. This was well before the days of Kik, Snapchat, and Instagram, so games were the sole focus. The book displayed as 1,000 pages on the tiny screen. I read voraciously on the school bus and before bed. Xbox games were put on the back burner as I dove into the fictional world.

I downloaded the book on a Sunday evening before a birthday celebration at Grandma Cathie's house. Any event at Grandma Cathie's house guaranteed Graeter's ice cream and a few rounds of hide and go seek. On my dad's side of the family there are 7 of us. We played so much that I knew everyone's strengths and weaknesses. I knew where people would and wouldn't look. And I knew who wouldn't look in the same spot twice.

Maggie was the seeker the first round after downloading *Because of Mr. Terupt*. My first spot was in the coat closet in the basement laundry room. I hurried down the stairs, turned onto the white tile floor, and stepped into the concrete closet. Wafts of dry perfume greet me as I nestle my way behind the layer of coats and cocoon myself in a fur coat. My feet uncomfortably rested on a pile of shoe boxes.

Well, I'm here—I might as well start reading?

I pulled out my iPod and held the screen inches from my face. Whoa, this is actually really fun! After 20 or so pages I heard Maggie pitter-patter on the white tile floor. I turned off the iPod and began focusing on my breathing. She first opened the closet underneath the stairs, which was going to be my next location. Every step became louder as she placed her hand on the doorknob to the closet less than a foot from my head. I could hear her breathing. The door stood open and silence screamed as she carelessly glanced in. After a few breaths she closed the door and left unsuccessful. I waited until I heard her feet on the stairs before I moved locations to the other closet. I read another 20 pages, really enjoying the book, and was never found.

Most of the time everyone would give up. I would walk up the stairs gloriously and before I could say anything, Gabe would respond, “Yeah, Sam, we gave up 20 minutes ago.” I’ve always had a knack for hide and seek.

Because of Mr. Terupt depicts a 5th grade classroom from the perspective of seven different students. Each of the seven students comes from a different background and social circle. For the first half of the book they seem to live in their own spheres, despite Mr. Terupt’s efforts to bring them together. Then “the incident” happens.

A snowball fight broke out at recess one day and Mr. Terupt caught an ice ball to the head, which sent him into a coma. The second half of the book depicts how the classroom came together as a result of “the incident.” While reading, I couldn’t help but picture my own 5th grade teacher Mrs. Quell in the shoes of Mr. Terupt. What happens to the classroom if “the incident” happens to her?

Unfortunately the incident did happen. A decade later.

In 2021 she lost her oldest son Jack to fentanyl poisoning. It was sudden. He was a great guy and people were left confused. One year later she started Do It For Jack, a nonprofit educating the community on the dangers of fentanyl poisoning. Loveland, Cincinnati, and

the world at large have helped her spread awareness around this horrific circumstance.

Jack loved reading too.

People moved in and out of the diner in Oakland as they started their day. Keys jingled off belt loops. The waitress was greeted by name in the same warm fashion. Coffee and a warm breakfast gave guests a boost. There was a flow that I was not a part of, but rather witnessed. I wasn't in the water of society but rather surfing this wave. Spectating the movement. The movement of people, but also their dreams. Withering and wilting in slow motion as the dead walked on.

I left the diner and arrived at the train station to learn my train was delayed. I felt as if I was in this stage of limbo; I didn't want to leave the station but I wanted to keep moving. My feet began to explore the station. My eyes spotted a bookshelf. It was close to, but not quite in, the corner of the room. And it wasn't quite pressed up against the wall that it stood in front of. Yet it stood unassumed. The commuters, the town goers—no one seemed to bat an eye. Give One, Take One was written in Sharpie and taped onto the top of this wooden bookshelf. The books weren't extremely compelling. James Patterson, children's books, Bibles. Then I saw a torn cover that caught my eye. I saw the word "Alaska" as cigarette smoke rose up the cover.

I presumed it was a gritty book surrounding an oil rig. It matched perfectly with McCandless's life in *Into the Wild*. I find a seat and sit back down. Not knowing how long I may be at this station, I prepared to hunker into this book. I come to find out it's about students off at boarding school!

The story is told by the main character, Miles, who memorizes the last words of famous people:

"So this guy, François Rabelais. He was this poet. And his last words were 'I go to seek a Great Perhaps.' That's why I'm going. So I don't have to wait until I die to start seeking a Great Perhaps."

The Great Perhaps became the focal point for this group of students having just moved away from home. What is life? What are we doing? His thoughts connected deeply to those of Thoreau and McCandless. What is a transition? These were asked over the story of loving, losing, grieving, and accepting the death of their friend Alaska. It reminded me of grade school relationships and infatuation.

I became so engrossed in this story that the 4-hour delay did not affect me. I finally got on the train at noon, well knowing there was 1 more stop and 8 hours to go. I transferred from a train to a bus in Martinez. The fields of wine country, rushing streams among the towering pines, and rolling foothills of the Sierras captivated my eyes and questions played in the background. I pondered the Great Perhaps. What was I doing with my life? What is going to happen after this trek? Where will I sleep tonight?

The bus arrived in Eureka 1 hour before sunset. The town did not want to reveal itself in full, as I could not see a few blocks ahead of me. A low fog hovered above and in between the Victorian buildings. Had I arrived at 4 pm, I would have walked to the beach 5 miles away. I made my way to the base of a narrow bridge. Mustering hope, I stuck out my thumb. Cars zoomed past and gave off dismissive glares. I couldn't mess around anymore; it was time to find a place.

I crossed over the narrow bridge. There was about a foot of space in between the outside yellow line and the 2-foot barrier to my right. I made sure to keep my balance to prevent falling into the rocky river to my right. As I made my way down the downslope of the bridge I saw a massive tree on the right-hand side of the road. The tree was on the other side of a wire fence next to a lagoon. I waited for the coast to be clear, tossed my pack over this fence, and hopped over. I quickly hid behind this tree and set up my tent. Nestling into the night, I turned on my headlamp and continued reading *Looking for Alaska*.

My alarm was set for 5:30 the next morning to prevent being found by any authorities. I made my way over the bridge and into town to witness the homeless rowdy cross. It was as if they were coming from every direction. A man with a cart arrived from the north. A man with a backpack came from the west. A man with a basket came from the east. It was as if they all knew each other.

I went to a coffee shop to relax for the morning and plot the remainder of the day. There is peace in dedicating an hour to journal. There was no rush, no pressure to perform, just to recall. I told the barista about the trek I was on and one of them recommended that I check out Jedediah Smith Redwoods State Park.

I sat in the back of the bus and continued reading *Looking for Alaska*. It was reminiscent of a 7th grade field trip to a youth camp called Camp Kern. We lived in cabins for 3 days and played games with classmates during the day. I became lost in grade school memories and didn't come up until I realized that the bus driver was pulling out of my stop.

“Excuse me, can you pull over?”

“No can do! There’s a stop a mile down the road.”

A jolly mustached man stood up a few rows ahead of me and said he was heading to the same place.

David

David and I set up our tents in a small clearing surrounded by trees. He had a shark-themed navy tent and sat inside the shark's open mouth cooking ramen noodles.

"Do you think you're going to stay tomorrow?" he asked.

"I don't think so, I'm heading up to Oregon. I've always wanted to go."

It was as if he was reminiscing about a past mistress. David looked up into the sun-kissed canopy of the redwood forest and let out, "Ahhh, Brookings."

Oregon was the far out I always dreamed of. The mountains, the deserts, the forests, the hipster cities, and most of all the rough and rugged coast.

At the turn of the century a businessman named Mike Keiser had the idea to build a golf course on the Southern Oregon Coast. Up until that point, people built golf resorts close to major cities. This was to keep the travel feasible. Keiser wanted to bring a more remote and adventurous feel to the game. He led with the belief of "Build it and they will come." He built one, which led to two, which has now led to seven courses comprising the Bandon Dunes Golf Resort. Keiser didn't stop in Oregon. The same philosophy led to resorts in the remote regions of Nova Scotia, Colorado, and Wisconsin.

As opposed to making a once-in-a-lifetime trip out to Bandon, I wanted to build a relationship with the property. I wanted to be suspended on top of the cliffs. To hear the waves, watch them crash into the sea stacks, and be surrounded by the game I love.

The idea of caddying post-grad popped in my head after reading Bud, Sweat, and Tees. Golf had always been the center point of my life in high school and even during COVID. After COVID, there was a rift. The fraternity golf trip and occasional weekend rounds couldn't quite fill the void. I picked up turf management classes as a segue to being on a golf course every day.

After a semester of turf management classes, I had a summer gig lined up at Keiser's property in Wisconsin, Sand Valley.

Sand Valley was pretty far out. It was a few hours from Madison and 25 minutes to the local coffee shop. The 2,000-person population of Nekoosa, WI could only staff so much! So they bring in and house all of their employees, and we're not just talking golfers. They pulled their

wait and custodial staff from Asia, Europe, and Africa. I would walk into the kitchen/common room at 4 am to make my breakfast and see a group of Asians still awake chain-smoking cigs watching Adele music videos. Other mornings the flick of the light switch would reveal someone still drunk on the couch and they would scurry back to their room in order to get ready for the day.

Oh, but the sun! To feel it, to know it. I started most days covered in a sweatshirt and rain shell. It was tranquil while layered up mowing greens in the dark. I listened to podcasts and albums to pass the time. But as the sun rose above the horizon it turned into a ticking time bomb. Very little tree cover provided shade and the baseball hat I wore wasn't cutting it. I went into the pro shop one day after work in search of more cover. In the corner of the room there was an extra-wide-brim white hat with a chin cord underneath. It was a no-brainer. Wearing that hat every day felt like an adventure.

After the summer in Wisconsin it sat in the closet. I brought it to the desert and now it made its way up the coast. As David glanced up into the canopy, my eyes followed, glancing over the white hat resting on the picnic table. He repeated, "Ahhh, Brookings."

David was a truck driver for Western Express. He had a red Mack with a rear cabin. Hailing from Riverside County, just east of LA, his routes primarily kept him in Southern California. On rare occasions he moved freight in the Pacific Northwest.

He found himself crossing the border into Oregon during May of 2020. His truck unfortunately broke down a few miles outside a town called Brookings. Unsure of where to go, he made his way to the nearest church. He stumbled upon St. Anthony Parish, who happened to be giving out COVID shots. David figured why not, he had not had a shot. Additionally, the first 10 people to receive a shot were given two free nights in a motel.

He could not refuse. While his truck was being repaired he made his way to Harris Beach State Park to explore the rugged coastline. In detail he described the sea stack formations and the composition of the rocky beach.

"Oh, you will not believe it! It is so fantastic. Fan-tas-tico! You've gotta go see it with your own eyes. You will not believe it."

I knew where my next stop was going to be. We said goodnight and went to sleep.

Morning Of

When I awoke the next morning it was well past sunrise. There was a buzz that had already begun. Cars filed into the campground one after the other. I tied my hiking boots and swooped my white wide-brim hat off the picnic table as I made my way to the restroom. Along the way a white 4Runner pulled up beside me and asked, "Which way is it to 311?"

I pointed them over to where the 300s were. Did they think I worked at the park? It must've been the hat.

While vacationers continued to file in, David and I were in no rush. Time seemed to fade into the background of the beautiful scene. Sun crept its way through the canopy, leaving pockets of warmth and chilliness. I journaled by my tent while he watched Fox News on his phone. By midmorning we decided to walk into town. We enjoyed lunch together.

As we walked back to the site I asked him, "Are you coming into Oregon?"

"I don't know just yet. I typically stay at one spot for a few nights before I move again. You should definitely go, it is so beautiful. You won't believe your own eyes."

After arriving at the campsite I made my way to the river to swim. I found a pair of goggles on the way that allowed me to see big swarms of fish moving down the river. Big jagged rocks sat on the floor, but they were out of reach over 15+ feet deep. It felt like I was in an aquarium.

Brookings was calling so I made my way back to the campsite and packed up.

"David, are you coming?"

I don't remember what he said, or if he said anything, but he began packing up with me.

The route was very similar to the day prior. We took a few buses, got dropped off at a gas station, and had a mile walk to the campsite. The coast hid behind a dense tree line as we hurried to the park.

"Oh, you're not going to believe it!" David continually reminded me.

A dispensary appeared along the way and we bought a \$4 joint. What better way to celebrate spontaneous friendship?

Harris Beach State Park was perched on top of a hillside in a forest of its own. We paid \$5 for the hiker-biker campsite and set up as fast as possible. After my tent was up, I pulled out my cook set to make some food but David assured me that it could wait.

The coast was heaven at first glance. It was only a football field away down a long drive and felt like we had made our way into a utopian playground. The noncontinuous beach gave way to family photos. Couples enjoyed themselves in the sand. High school kids played soccer. Children played in the pools of water that had accumulated throughout the beach. Groups of people used the washed-up driftwood to build huts. People walked as they pleased and sat down wherever they wanted.

David walked to the south side of the beach and did not falter where it appeared to end. I lagged behind him, unable to put my camera down. We climbed over and in between rocks until it made way for another beach.

“Look at that! Look at that! This is what I wanted to show you!” David pointed to a rock shaped like an inverted slingshot. A tall rock diverged above the water, allowing a channel to flow through it. We sparked the joint and began to question. How does this happen? The natural erosion of a structure allowing for beauty to emerge? The random incidents leading to the most beautiful encounters? The ability to trust a stranger after a brief interaction?

This nook of the world had magic that I couldn’t ignore. At that moment I was set on moving here and starting a new life. I pointed to the cliffs in the distance and told David, “I’m going to move here and live in that house.”

“Yes you will, I can already see it.”

We made our way back to the campsite. As we passed, people photographed the sunset behind one sea stack and the full moon rising above another. Cars filed out with their headlights on and once we arrived at the campsite we noticed people had already fallen asleep. I still had an appetite built up from all of the walking, so I made some rice and tuna.

I’m going to go back to Ohio, then I’m going to find a job in the area, and then move to the coast. I drifted deeper and deeper into this fantasy as I had found a home. I wondered if it was safe to go back down to the beach and walk around outside. Before entertaining that idea I wanted to clean my cook set and brush my teeth.

With my cook set, microfiber towel, and toiletries I made my way to find the bathhouse. After taking a few steps, I walked back to the picnic table, swooped my white wide-brim hat,

and placed it on my head.

I began walking into the RV-filled campsite yet I did not see a single soul. Music and television played from inside the vehicles. I could not see anybody in or around them. The gravel path led me to a dead end next to a playground. On the other side of the swing set I saw a brick structure with a half-opened door.

Finally!

I made my way inside to see a man shaving at the far left sink.

“Nice hat, son, that’s a bold look.”

“Thank you, sir,” I said as I set my things on the metal sheet just above the far right sink. My cook set made its way out of its baggie and into the sink. I turned on the faucet and warm water appeared! Warm water in a campsite bathroom! This was going to make washing my pot of rice so easy. My spork began scraping the charred rice in my bowl.

The man continued, “I met a girl at a hat store once. She’s from North Carolina, while I’m from South Carolina. So she goes...”

“You’re a Gamecock!” he said to himself in a lady voice.

“So I go, nooooo. I’m Roy Cooper. A chicken! A chicken? Are you calling me a chicken?”

“She says, ‘I already haveee a boyfriend!’” he repeated in a lady voice.

“How old is he?”

“He’s about your age.”

“Well can I tell you what your problem is?”

“She says, sure.”

“He doesn’t look like me! ...I married that woman 4 days later. We had 6 kids together. Right now she’s in North Carolina with our grandbaby boy. But me, I’m not leaving this town ’til I find who murdered my momma...”

It was as if the grime off the tile floor elevated and whooshed its way out of the half-opened door. The flickering light in the corner came to a halt. Warm water continued to rush over my soot-filled fingernails.

My head tilted left and followed the sink until I looked up into the mirror and met bloodshot eyes. Upon a deeper look I saw this man's soul paddling upstream into the red rapids of his own despair.

I heard a voice that told me to stand here and listen to what this man had to say.

"You've gotta keep your eyes open in this county, son. The only reason I'm not dead is because I'm a criminal myself. I've done murder. Killed my stepdad at 14 because he was beating my momma..."

North Carolina, South Carolina, hat store, stepdad 14. I went deep inside my memory to begin storing as much information as possible. My shoulders retracted and I tilted my chin just a little higher to hide any lingering fear. After 30 seconds of training my memory, I came to and Roy continued on.

"...The FBI hatedddd me. Oh, we robbed jewelry stores all across the country. We had a lookout man, a getaway driver, and I would go in there and get out. Lickety-split. Oh, Texas, I loved Texas! We didn't get caught until Chicago. I hate Chicago. We gave money to the less fortunate and got caught."

I chimed in, "Like Robin Hood."

He let out a resounding, "Yeahhhh, you're right..."

"...This town is run by a man named David Garvin. But everyone calls him David Gardner. If you have a deputy title you get a spoofed-up last name. But son, you tell me what. This man is a registered sex offender in Sacramento. How does he still have his deputy position?

This man, he owns the banks, the nursing homes, the insurance companies. Hell, the nearest hospital is 20 miles up the road in Gold Beach. Down here it's all traveling nurses. There's so much money in healthcare, son, people will do anything."

"...That's where my mom passed away, one of his nursing homes. They found uranium in her bloodstream during her autopsy! Why the fuck was there uranium in her bloodstream! I've been hounding the insurance companies forever now and they won't let me know the reason she died! I hate insurance companies..."

"...Son, these hills are screaming at night. Little boys and little girls everywhere. We're talking sex trafficking, big time. I've walked into the Ace Hardware and they've rearranged the floor setup 3 times in the past month. Tell me why they are rearranging Ace Hardware 3 times in

one month? Nothing good!”

“This place is a hotbed for first-stage fentanyl production. It turns into air that animals breathe in and it gives them Roger Rabbit eyes. I was over on Route 308 looking into the backwoods and I saw a Bronco run straight into a barbed wire fence. There is nothing stopping this stuff on Hwy 101. It goes right into California and no one bats an eye. Mexico’s president doesn’t think this stuff is being made in Mexico, he knows it’s coming from somewhere else...”

I couldn’t help but think of Mrs. Quell and her son Jack. Is this really where it’s coming from?

“...The rich give the homeless crack to test out their product and then the homeless destroy the rich property. But the rich have insurance claims on their property so it’s a win-win for them. But you know how much these tweakers need this stuff! It’s gotten so bad that they lock the public restrooms and dumpsters each night. This is the only place people can clean up... How old are you, son?”

“I’m 22.”

“Man, you look mature! I had you for 30, 35.”

Alright, I’ve built two pieces of rapport with this man. My shoulders retracted more and my chin tilted higher. Maybe I could be this guy’s sidekick?

“...I’m a baddd man. I’ve been a criminal for 30 years. I’ve done my time. Hell, I was getting laid in the warden’s office. It was my yard, it was MY yard. But I try to be a good guy. I’ll pick up tweakers in the back of a U-Haul to keep them safe. I carry Narcan around in case anyone needs it. One day I had tweakers in the back and I was going over the bridge. I saw a teenager ready to jump.”

Roy placed his hands on top of his head and closed his eyes, begging, “Don’t jump, please don’t jump! I’m telling you don’t jump. Look, son, I’m having a bad day, someone stole my Narcan. Please don’t jump... You also don’t want to jump because I threw someone off this bridge one time. I was bouncing one time... Son, do you know why they called them bouncers? English boxers used to own 6–8 bars in an area and to make sure they kept their reputation...”

He inched closer to me with his razor in his right hand and placed his fingers on my collar, the razor just inches away from my neck, and thrust my collar.

“...They would bounce your collar to check to see if it was sturdy...”

Roy Cooper moved back to his sink and began shaving his eyebrows.

“Son, don’t worry, you’ll be shaving your eyebrows one day too. But when I shave my eyebrows I look too good! Then Fat Nancy wants to have me over, gollee! You wouldn’t believe my luck, son. I’m a 6-time widower. But that luck also happens on the other side. The first time I walked into a casino I left with \$22,000! That was probably because my momma had 7 card tables growing up.”

Roy set his razor on the thin metal sheet above the sink. Also on the sheet, there was a tube of paste and two plastic gloves. Roy placed the gloves on his hands, one by one. Then he uncapped the tube and black paste emerged. He rubbed the paste in between the gloves that were clearly too big for his hands. The paste was smeared over his bald buzz cut, his eyebrows, and the remaining facial hair. Sweat blended with the black dye as heaps of black liquid began to travel down his face. After a minute of this unruly sight, he took off his shirt and began to wipe it off.

His body was decorated. There was a big galleon sailing ship on his right shoulder. A red dragon took up his left shoulder and back area. On his left pectoral lay his alter ego, written in ornate cursive: “*Cowboy*.” After taking in his body art I could not help but notice what was hanging off his belt. There hung a knife 7 inches long, enclosed in a nylon sheath.

He ruffled through his bags, currently shirtless, wearing ripped denim jeans and what appeared to be black steel-toe work boots. “I’m going to hit the shower,” he said. We walked outside the half-opened door together to find 2 police officers locking up the door to the showers. “Ohhh, you can’t be locking these up on me now!”

“Showers close at 10,” one of the officers said.

In a trance-like state we both floated back into the bathroom.

“...Son, is Jeffrey Epstein alive?”

“Who knows?”

“Well, I know a man even more powerful! He runs with Gardner, his name is Mike Popper. They call him Puffin. They say a man was chopping firewood in his front yard with his family on the porch. Puffin went right up and shot him in front of his family. They’re ruthless. The cops won’t do anything in this town, they don’t care. I spend time in the library doing my research, watching out for people. A lady cop comes in and looks at me and says, ‘Hey, I know what you’re doing, you better stop.’ Lady! I’m a homicidal maniac! Do you know who you’re talking to?! Someone has to do something about it. Well that’ll be me, I’m cowboyyyy. If I die, I die, but I’m not afraid of nobody in this here county. I’m a homicidal maniac for God’s sake.”

That was the sign for me to exit.

I began making my way out of the door, saying goodnight on the way. He followed me outside, his clothes bound up in his arms. He gave me a knuckle bump and said, “There’s this new clay they’re finding in the crust that could sell for \$11,000 a pound. Son, it’s about to be a new gold mine. Keep your ears out for this.”

I took the gravel road back to the hiker-biker campsite. Every hundred feet I would peer over my shoulder to make sure that he wasn’t chasing me with his knife. I quietly walked into the campsite and tiptoed into my tent. I put my headlamp on my head and turned it to the dim red setting. I curled up in my sleeping bag and began writing as much as I could remember in my journal.

I filled 7 pages.

In Town

The next morning we woke up to the birds and the faint sound of waves crashing on the sea stacks in the bay just beneath us. David came out of his shark tent while cooking some noodles over his camp stove, listening to Fox News. The program was detailing the fentanyl crisis in the United States and the number of deaths over the past year.

I pull out my cook set to make some instant coffee and oatmeal. The breakfast of kings. The minute labor and simplicity of cooking amongst the rugged beauty is a humbling experience. Completely ignoring what happened the night prior, we talked about our plans for the day.

David mentioned the idea of swimming in the ocean and renting wetsuits. He laughed and joked about how we would look like seals to the sharks in the ocean.

“If we’re going to look like seals, I would have to bring my knife in with me, I would have to!”

He reached into his backpack and pulled out a knife of similar length to Roy Cooper’s. He began slashing the air, pretending to knife sharks in the water. As he’s talking he’s laughing, and then laughing at his laugh, and then he starts hysterically laughing at his own jokes in such a jovial manner that I find myself unable to breathe from excessive laughter.

We finish our breakfast and decide that we will head into town to explore. David wanted to see St. Anthony, the church that helped him out years ago.

As we’re about to leave during the midmorning, a man pushing a bike with a six-pack of Bud Light, wearing an Indians hat, comes through the gates of the hiker-biker site. “Nice hat, son,” he said, and gave me a head nod. Caught off guard, I take a deeper look. It’s Roy Cooper heading to the back right corner of the campsite. I was completely baffled and unsure of whether to tell David about the night prior.

As we made our way to town we met a couple that told us about a trail we could take, rather than the road we came in on. Shrubbery and dense tree lines stood in between us and the roadside, so it felt like we were on another planet with far views, vast sea stacks, and rugged shorelines.

David would talk to whoever we passed, telling them our story. He said, “I’m from Riverside County and he’s from Iowa. And we met the other day and we’ve been traveling together since.” I would correct him, saying I’m from Ohio, but it never seemed to stick. Outside of

California, all the states seemed the same to him.

There were openings in the trail that allowed views of the ocean. Birds swooped around over the relatively empty beaches. Taking note and related to the freedom in their soaring and companionship. We exited the trail and made our way into the city limits.

The first thing we saw was a man resembling Jabba the Hutt sitting down, leaning his back against the telephone pole. He asked us in a scratchy voice, "Do you have any cigarettes?"

David let out a startled "eek!" as we continued to walk past.

Just past this man there was a motel, the AmeriCoast Inn, that appeared to be empty. Yet there were still cars in the parking lot.

They were filing out in a single-file line, the first of them being a U-Haul, followed by a pickup truck with two pit bulls in the back, followed by three motorcyclists.

As they're stopped at the light, David and I walk past them. I looked into the back of the pickup truck and made eye contact with the two pit bulls. Not wanting to look inside the tinted windows, I shifted my eyes forward. I turned my head towards the motel lot and did not see any other cars present.

We continued walking, getting closer to the main strip with all the restaurants and bars. And David mentioned to me, "Nice hat. I really like your hat. I want to get myself one of those."

"Yeah, I think a hat would look great on you, David."

We made our way to the Goodwill in search of a hat for David. This Goodwill happened to be connected to the community of St. Anthony's. We walk into the Goodwill and head towards the hat section, which is a metal basket on top of a clothing rack. He begins trying on a bunch of different hats as we laugh and find humor in this dress-up show.

"I need to put these things in a cart so they don't charge me and think I'm a basket case!"

He decides on a tan fishing hat, which matched his personality and the grey button-down he wore.

As we're checking out, David is talking with the cashier, asking if Jeanie was still here and how she helped him during the time of distress in the COVID days. She said no, she didn't know of such a person.

Midway through this conversation, a tweaker walked past us in the checkout line. He was wearing a black security hat, construction jacket, white shirt with red lifeguard lettering, and cargo swim shorts. He was making inaudible sounds and words, groaning and moaning, walking through the store.

The cashier displayed sympathy for the man by letting out an “Awww.”

I asked what was going on and she said, “He typically has a lady that’s also a little uhhh uhhh in the head too. They typically come in here together each day but she isn’t here today. Poor guy.”

It seems as if tweakers are normalized in this town. People are unable to formulate words and sentences, wandering around, barely able to walk.

I was still perplexed by the conversation with Roy from the night prior. I still can’t believe what goes on in this town. Walking alongside the sidewalk, heading to Dairy Queen to get some ice cream, David pointed to a car saying, “Hey, look, Labradoodles. Haha, Labradoodles.” We admired the two dogs hanging their heads out of windows as they caught the midsummer sun.

We walked through a strip mall parking lot as we heard rattling and screeching coming from behind us. A man rode a shopping cart like a scooter as he passed us and continued on.

Before arriving at Dairy Queen, the man resembling Jabba the Hutt from three hours ago passed us on the sidewalk with the same scraggly voice: “Do you have any cigarettes?”

David said, “Didn’t we just see him back there? This place is the Twilight Zone!”

We enjoyed our Blizzards and headed back to the campsite.

The evening was tame. The beachfront held a similarly diverse crowd, equally captivated by the beauty that was apparent the night prior. After sunset I headed into the bathroom, subtly hoping Roy would be there shaving once again, to get even more information on what went down in this town. I was there alone. I took my good ole time in case he happened to be running late. Walking back to the site I kept my eyes peeled for any more suspicious activity. No human was in sight but the music and TV shows continued to play.

Road to Bandon

The next morning David and I decided to head north. Bandon Dunes was at the forefront of my mind and I wanted to show David a piece of my heart, as he had just shared part of his. We walked to the bus stop by midmorning and made our way north on Hwy 101.

David and I continued to have a jolly time on the bus. He talked to the driver about driving trucks and connected with his life on the road. The bus made a stop at a gas station where 3 through-hikers hopped on. We were 5 minutes from the Bandon bus stop.

Amidst laughter from David and me, a clear foreigner asked, “Are you father and son?”

Excited to share the situation, I responded, “No, I just met him 3 days ago and we’ve been traveling since.”

“Oh, that’s fun. Where are you guys going now?”

“We’re heading to the Coos Bay, Bandon area. Where are you coming from and where are you going?”

“I just finished the Oregon Coast Trail and I’m heading into Eugene. I’ve stayed at a hostel there before and I wanted to be around people for the Fourth.”

“Nice! That sounds fun, do you know if the hostel has any open rooms?”

“They probably will, but I’m not sure. Do you want to go?”

I looked at David. “Want to go to Eugene?”

“Hey, I’m following you,” David replied.

The bus came to a halt at the Bandon stop. I looked at the open door and the town sign through the window. Taking a deep sigh, I realized I wanted to follow the adventure. “Yeah, let’s head into Eugene.”

A few stops later, David, the Frenchman named Florian, and I hopped off into a Walmart parking lot. We sat in a grassy area waiting for the next bus. Florian recalled his 400-mile trek down the coast as I basked in the pack we found ourselves in.